To understand the level of desperation, it is worth stressing just how awful the fate is that awaits those Rohingyas who do flee. In previous years, the people smugglers took most of them to Thailand, Indonesia or Malaysia, where they effectively worked as slave labourers or disappeared into the undocumented, unprotected labour force. Slave labour is commonly used in the regional prawn fishing industry, especially in Thailand, where it has become a significant part of the labour force.[82] Some estimates suggest that as many as 500,000 slaves work in Thailand,[83] and many are refugees from Myanmar. Some report that they had entered Thailand illegally, were caught by the police, and then handed over to the boat owners:

> 'One day I was stopped by the police and asked if I had a work permit,' says Ei Ei Lwin, 29, a Burmese migrant who was detained on the docks at Songkhla port. 'They wanted a 10,000 baht (£180) bribe to release me. I didn't have it, and I didn't know anyone else who would, so they took me to a secluded area, handed me over to a broker, and sent me to work on a trawler.'[84]

In Thailand slaves are now very cheap, in part due to the influx from Myanmar and in part due to the complicity of the Thai authorities. It has been estimated that the price of a human being is now 5 per cent of what it was in the nineteenth century. Modern-day slaves in the region are so cheap they are now seen as disposable.[85] Migrants quickly became aware of the threat of being sent to sea on the fishing boats: 'They told me I was going to work in a pineapple factory', recalls Kyaw, a broad-shouldered twenty-one-year-old from rural Burma. 'But when I saw the boats, I realised I'd been sold … I was so depressed, I wanted to die'.[86]

Thailand has become the centre of this foul trade due to its lax regulations for its fishing industry and the extent of corruption between the police and people-smugglers. There is also emerging evidence that this collusion has involved senior military and police officials[87] who have not just been forcing those caught in Thailand into slavery but actually organising the trafficking of Rohingyas for the explicit purpose of selling them into slavery to create the economic basis of the Thai fishing industry.

Due to local over-fishing, Thai boats have started to operate off Indonesia, Malaysia and Myanmar, and cheap slave labour has become a crucial part of their economic model. Fuel for such long journeys is expensive, as is feeding and paying the crews. Slave labour is so cheap that if the slaves starve, are lost at sea or killed by the captains, it is easy to replace them.[88] Other Thai vessels have abandoned fishing altogether for